

## Notes on the Poetic Image of the *Patria*

P. M. PASINETTI

In a larger measure than perhaps any of the other countries of major cultural caliber, Italy for many centuries could be regarded as an invention of its poets. From at least the time when Dante was writing the divine poem to the time when Leopardi was a young man, the country which did not exist as a unified political entity was a congruous reality and an important image through the work of its poets. Indeed, literature did not create only an image of Italy but concomitantly also that of the poets themselves as her natural interpreters and judges. We have the most memorable instances in mind when we say that the attitude of those great Italians toward Italy, whose image they so potently contributed to form, is quite complex and critical. They were giving the country her literary speech and in the highest examples they did not use it in an exclamatory and celebrative vein; on the contrary, the typical attitude is one of manly compassion and sorrowful censure.

The standard sequence to describe this line is Dante-Petrarch-Machiavelli. One of the running themes in Italy's national poem is that of national corruption and lack of leadership; the time-honored metaphor of the ship of state is used by Dante; and the ship, as everyone remembers, is a pilotless one in a stormy sea. As frequently in classical tragedy, the *polis* is corrupt, its rulers are inadequate, the temporal center does not hold. Italy, of course, is feminine; ideally the noblest of women (*donna*, *domina*), she is "now" lacerated through the behavior of inept and quarrelsome children — a state

of affairs which Dante was certainly neither the first nor the last to visualize, though he did so, as usual, in the most definitive and memorable diction: *non donna di provincie, ma bordello*. Somewhat more diffusely and sensuously, Petrarch resumed the image of the *patria* as the lacerated lady in the splendidly eloquent and sorrowful opening of *Italia mia*; later in the poem, the native earth is identified with the image of the benign and pious mother ("Non è questo 'l terren ch' i' toccai pria?... Non è questa la patria in ch'io mi fido, / Madre benigna e pia / Che copre l'un e l'altro mio parente?")<sup>1</sup> In the same poem the theme of Italy-Romanism vs. Teutonism-Barbarity, a theme in many ways fraught with rhetorical danger, also makes its solemn appearance. It will be imitated, and involuntarily caricatured, in patriotic versifying and in political oratory for centuries. The noblest and most magniloquent resumption of that theme is, of course, in the close of Machiavelli's *Prince* ending with the Petrarch quotation about *virtù* and *furor*. The Machiavelli passage is also significant because it comes at the close of a political treatise famed for the practicality of its assumptions and views; the cultural dream of the *patria* finds one of its major expressions in Machiavelli, who, incidentally, considered himself a poet.

Several centuries later, a conclusive expression, along this poetic line, by a major poet, is the dyptich of *canzoni* composed by Leopardi when he was twenty years old (1818), *All'Italia* and *Sopra il monumento di Dante*. Especially *All'Italia* with its classic opening, "O patria mia," etc., can be described as an exercise in patriotic poetry in the grand manner; the poet, the Nation's *vates*, is officiating, performing a literary rite; reference to the Petrarchan tradition is not only natural, it is part of the *genre's* requirements; the poem is a ceremony, with its proper formulas. It must be observed, however, that young Leopardi's poetic and civic vitality did emerge nevertheless, making him, at this early stage at least, a true Risorgi-

mento poet — for instance in the presentation of the theme, in itself not new, of his contemporary Italians compelled to fight not *against* but *for* those who are ultimately their tyrants, and the particular visions of that fighting in the remote Russian campaign. The structure, the speech, the oratorical motions are within the grand cultural convention, and so is the opening image of the *patria*, for we have here again, as in Petrarch, the beautiful lacerated lady, elaborated upon quite dramatically (... "Oimè quante ferite, / Che lividor, che sangue! oh qual ti veggio, / Formosissima donna!")<sup>2</sup> with the concomitant attributes of defenselessness and servitude. Along this line, however, the image of the *patria* has acquired some new connotations and emphases; for a moment it becomes closer to the romantic image of the beautiful, weeping slave-girl, who "...sparte le chiome e senza velo / Siede in terra negletta e sconsolata, / Nascondendo la faccia / Tra le ginocchia, e piange."<sup>3</sup> Then a more historical perspective is resumed: "Piangi, che ben hai donde, Italia mia, / Le genti a vincer nata / E nella fausta sorte e nella ria,"<sup>4</sup> where the supposedly ambiguous line obviously means that Italy once surpassed other nations in fortune and glory and now does so in the degree of her misfortune and sorrow. While this vision can be vaguely related, on the one side, to the Dante-Machiavelli theme (cf. *Purg.*, VI, 121-123 and *Prince*, opening of last chapter) of the extremity of wretchedness, seen by them as a possible anticipation of future rescue, on the other it can be connected with that view of greatness-in-sorrow, of glory-in-calamity, which permeates, for example, the close of Foscolo's *Sepolcri*. So, while the Leopardi poem is firmly anchored in the tradition and its linguistic character, some of its themes qualify it as early Risorgimento poetry. Exemplary in this sense are the lines where the speaker assumes the rôle of the patriot, of the lonely defender of his beloved nation, ready to die for her: in terms of diction, these lines are

characterized by a famous and ponderous Latinism (... "procomberò sol io.")

In Risorgimento poetry we witness then a sort of melting, more or less gradual and conscious, of the image of the *patria* as object of filial devotion with that of the *patria* as the beloved woman. This rhetorical situation is clearer if we see it from the point of view of the change that has occurred in the position of the patriotic poet himself. Biographical critics have observed, in this connection, that the period of composition of Leopardi's *All'Italia* coincided with that of the poet's love for the Signora Cassi, of course unrequited. But, along this line (romantic love and love of country providing, as it were, a similar emotional temperature) the most influential archetype was and remained Jacopo Ortis, the hero of Foscolo's famous epistolary novel.

*Le ultime lettere di Jacopo Ortis* follows, as everyone knows, the same pattern as Goethe's *Werther* (love; marriage of the beloved to another man; suicide); and it will be sufficient here briefly to recall some of the ways in which the Werther pattern is reworked by Foscolo. Jacopo, his hero, is an exile and a wanderer, the victim of political persecution, and chooses death not only because Lotte's counterpart, Teresa, is unattainable, but also because the country is oppressed and hope of freedom is frustrated. Her marriage to the marquis Odoardo is explained not only in terms of rank but also of political expediency, to protect Teresa's father who like the hero is a political suspect; Teresa herself describes the marriage as having been already *decretato*. Unlike Lotte, she is decidedly in love with the hero but has to follow the family and social "decree" thus occupying the position of a victim, a pawn; and although the parallel is by no means forced upon us by the text, there is similarity between the language with which the protagonist refers to his country's plight (Venice, but easily symbolizing a more general Italian situation) and that of Teresa. See the

opening words of the book: "Il sacrificio della patria è consumato,"<sup>75</sup> and the words used at the news of Teresa's marriage: "La vittima è sacrificata,"<sup>76</sup> etc. So that De Sanctis is justified (*Nuovi saggi critici*, Naples 1879, p. 148) in observing that Teresa married to Odoardo "è come la Venezia della sua mente finita in braccio all'Austria."<sup>77</sup>

\* \* \*

The *patria* of the poets preceding the active Risorgimento was by definition, then, something "of the mind", a cultural point of reference, a bookish experience; but the interesting thing is that with the later poets, the ones who were concerned with or indeed actively engaged in the country's liberation, and wrote poetry to spur their countrymen in that direction, the current image of the *patria* frequently works in an even more abstract, emblematic, bookish way than it had done before. In the opening of Leopardi's *All'Italia*, the vision of the *patria* in its past glory and present distress, in spite of the conventions of language still conveyed some feeling of rendered experience, strictly cultural, humanistic, as the experience was. Similar remarks could apply to the use that both Foscolo and Leopardi, each in his way, make of Greek and Trojan antiquity and myth, the theme of ancient valor and loyalty contrasted to present impotence.

Now, when the *patria* as object of the poet's allegiance and the reason for his valor was no longer a cultural *contaminatio* but a concrete historical possibility, its poetic images remained, by and large, the cultural ones. Poet-patriots who, like Berchet or Mameli, by their actual participation in history, were contributing to create the tangible *patria*, with its successes and defeats, marvelous exploits and appalling problems, once it came to defining its image in verse still used, re-shuffled, the tired materials of cultural patriotic poetry. The results, in the new historical context, were to be felt beyond their time,

*Painters*

*of the*

"RISORGIMENTO"



A. CASSIOLI: *The Battle of San Martino.*

A. CASSIOLI: *The Battle of Palestro.*



beyond the time of the unification of the country and even in our own century (for instance in certain aspects of *dannunzianesimo*, in common types of patriotic oratory and political imagery, etc.) a dichotomy was established between the actualities of the nation and the official, emblematic, Sunday-dress images of its cult. The obvious cluster of images has to do, of course, with ancient Rome, whose spirit now awakened will spell ruin to the barbaric oppressor and restore the lacerated and betrayed lady to a queenly position:

Sperai rinato il genio  
Del tuo valor primiero,  
Che Roma al mondo intero  
Centro faceva un dì.

Quivi — sull'Alpe — i secoli  
Della tua gloria stanno;  
A' tuoi signori, ai popoli  
Testimonianza fanno  
Che vil non sei, non debole  
Ma oppressa, ma tradita,  
Che se ti desti a vita  
Sarai regina ancor.

Ora su te si compie  
Legge fatal di pianto,  
Sparso è il tuo crin di cenere,  
Lacero e brutto il manto;  
Ma suonerà terribile  
L'ora de' santi sdegni  
Che lo spavento insegni  
Al barbaro oppressor.<sup>8</sup>

These lines were written by no less than Giuseppe Mazzini, who was, to be sure, by no means primarily a poet; but I think we can agree that they have the sound of standard Risorgimento poetry. While we are at it, we may offer few lines by another major Risorgimento figure:

Lo stranier la mia terra calpesta,  
Il mio gregge macella, il mio onor

Vuol strapparmi; ma un ferro mi resta,  
Un acciar per ferirlo nel cor.

Non sei stanco di giogo, d'oltraggi,  
Di codarde lusinghe, d'inganni?  
Questa terra servili e tiranni  
Solo porta, ma prodi non più?"

The battling images here ("un ferro," "un acciar") stylistically suggest the opera stage more than they do the battlefield. The dichotomy between *Erlebnis* and *Dichtung* could not appear more sharply, if we think that the author of the lines is Garibaldi.

The major argument to support the idea that my quotations are unfair would not so much be that Mazzini and Garibaldi were not professional poets (for that matter, Risorgimento poets are, in all textbook definitions, "minor") but rather that the historical situation itself justified the conventional, oversimplified poetic utterance. Action, the argument could run, means practical decision as to what is right and what is wrong, there is no room for complexity of image and feeling. The counter-argument, however, could be that this poetry, while meant to be simple and popular, has recourse to the cultural, literate, bookish speech and imagery; that while it is meant for "the people," it is by no means *easy*. True, its basic situation, its moral pattern, is simple: Italy, enslaved for centuries, will achieve freedom through the unity of her children, vanquishing and chasing her barbarous oppressors. However, even in the proverbially famous texts, the ones which have become national anthems, the language and imagery do not necessarily possess the immediacy and clarity which their popularity would warrant. To use again the most obvious area of exemplification, see the all-pervading reference to Roman imagery. We are, of course, so used to Mercantini's *Inno di Garibaldi* and Mameli's *Fratelli d'Italia* that their imagery has become transparent, we perceive it no longer; but if we try for a moment to see it from a totally fresh point

of view, I believe it can be argued that it contains an irremediable, basic complexity and that its remoteness from any possible *Erlebnis* on the part of "the people" is still striking. Words of patriotic anthems should not be quibbled about; I still believe that their "complexity" is worth mentioning. Here, for instance, fighters for freedom are asked to follow the example of their resurrected heroic dead who go again into battle *le spade nel pugno, gli allori alle chiome*; and the *patria*, of course, wears *l'elmo di Scipio*, while hope of victory is expressed through that rather involved image about Victory being "Rome's slave." To go to battle, our military formation will be the Roman *cohors*: the contemporary experience is transcribed into ancient Roman key. The poet Goffredo Mameli, be it remembered, fell at 22 in the heroic defense of the Roman Republic, had probably a good political awareness of what he was doing in his historical context, and justly stands as a symbol of valor and sacrifice for the cause of freedom.

One conclusion, then, as Mr. Speroni aptly shows in this same issue of the *Quarterly*, is that although a good deal of this body of poetry was written to be sung, and some still is, there is hardly any bona fide "popular" poetry here. In a much later and different social context — the period of the First World War — more properly popular songs may have emerged, such as those connected with the Alpine troops in Northern Venetia: speech and imagery are concrete, not without crudeness, semi-vernacular. The Risorgimento songs, by and large, are neither the anonymous "voice of people" nor cultured attempts to discover that voice and give it expression; they are conventional compositions produced by the literate middle class, that is, by the people who did make the Risorgimento (witness, to give a usual example, the list of Garibaldi's Thousand and their backgrounds and professions), brought up, as far as poetry and literature went, on a reverence for classical culture, and permeated

with all of the varied Italian rhetorics from Roman to Romantic, through such phases of poetic taste (by no means wholly negative in their effects) as the Arcadia.

Addio, mia bella, addio,  
L'armata se ne va;  
Se non partissi anch'io  
Sarebbe una viltà!<sup>10</sup>

This, after all, is a sort of drummed-up Metastasio.

\* \* \*

The linguistic instrument of these poets seems then to work more effectively, rather than in the attempts at conjuring up the more august and official images of the *patria*, in the presentation of the episodic detail, the limited romantic tableau of patriotic life. Here too, however, the qualities which we may roughly refer to as sentimentalism and melodrama often make it difficult to use these compositions even as period-pieces. This is the poetic counterpart to the so-called *pittura di genere*, it is the world inhabited by the wandering patriot-exile who "sempre ha la patria in cor"<sup>11</sup> (Berchet, *Le fantasie*), of the Italian woman cursed for having married a Teuton (same, *Il rimorso*: "Ella è sola dinnanzi le genti... — Maledetta chi d'italo amplesso / Il tedesco soldato beò! —"),<sup>12</sup> of the dead sailor's fiancée (Mercatini, *La fidanzata del marinaio di Lissa*: "Povero Turi mio, non può tornare! È in fondo al mare."),<sup>13</sup> of the soldier's farewell to his beloved, and countless other vignettes. To remain within the area of extremely popular instances, in *Addio, mia bella, addio*, which is the proverbial treatment of the farewell motif, written by a Florentine lawyer to be sung on a pre-existing popular air, "il brando" is gone and there is reference to "le pistole", "lo schioppo", "il moschetto", and other such tangible properties of the departing soldier. Even "Io vado in Lombardia / Incontro all'oppressor"<sup>14</sup>

is convincingly purposeful, both syntactically and geographically. Ippolito Nievo who, to mention only that, invented in *La Pisana* one of the few living feminine characters in Italian fiction, thus sings of his leader, General Garibaldi:

Ha un non so che nell'occhio  
Che splende dalla mente  
E a mettersi in ginocchio  
Sembra inchinar la gente;  
Pur nelle folte piazze  
Girar cortese, umano,  
E porgere la mano  
Lo vidi alle ragazze.  
Sia per fiorito calle  
In mezzo a canti e a suoni,  
Che tra fischianti palle  
E scoppio de' cannoni,  
Ei nacque sorridendo  
Né sa mutar di stile.  
Solo al nemico e al vile  
È l'occhio suo tremendo.<sup>15</sup>

This, at least, is speech practically unfiltered through "literature". For opposite reasons the more mature, well-informed, professional among the poets, like Berchet in the first Romantic generation, Prati and Aleardi in the second, are not necessarily the more felicitous. Berchet's *Clarina* bids her soldier-fiancé farewell in the average style of opera librettos:

Va', Gismondo; e qual ch'io sia  
non por mente alle mie pene.  
Una patria avevi in pria  
che donassi a me il tuo cor:  
rompi a lei le sue catene,  
poi t'inebria dell'amor.  
Va', combatti; e ne' perigli  
pensa, o caro, al dì remoto  
quando assiso in mezzo ai figli

tu festoso potrai dir:  
« Questo brando a lei devoto  
tolse Italia dal servir. » —<sup>16</sup>

The same poet "romanticizes" the father of the patriot Silvio Pellico turning him into the Romantic stock-character of the hermit (*Il romito del Ceniso*). In this direction a whole study could be conducted on the way a Romantic *Stimmung* and Romantic clichés are applied to the situations of patriotic poetry. For instance, in Prati's *Anniversario di Curtatone* the ghosts on a moonlit plain are those of the battle dead, later referred to as withered lilies on the *patria*'s brow ("...della bella Ausonia / gigli defunti al crin.") In a more discursive tone, in unrhymed endecasyllables, Aleardi in his poem called *Triste dramma* and subtitled *A te, donna, che sai*, addresses the forgetful beloved of a hanged patriot:

Ei salutò l'Italia  
serenamente . . . Un turbine a nebbie  
coperse il resto. A mezzo il dì dai vani  
ad or ad or de le fuggenti nubi  
usciva il sole a battere sul campo  
deserto, su la fune orrida, su la  
pendula salma d'un gentile ucciso,  
e su quel collo ahi! livido, che un tempo  
tu coprivi di baci.<sup>17</sup>

\* \* \*

Achieving a balance between cultivated poetry and communicable speech never seems to have been more difficult than with the Italian poets of this period; and naturally, the more cultured and ambitious run the greater risks. Some of these poets strike the most promising notes when the patriotic experience is rendered in personal terms and the tone is not that of hymn but rather that of the poetic meditation: examples could be found, in the second Romantic generation, in Aleardi himself (e.g.,

in some moments of *I tre fiumi*), or, in the earlier generation, in a poet who is largely neglected even by average educated Italians, Giovita Scalvini (*Il fuoruscito*). These, however, are hardly popular poems of the *patria* and do not give Risorgimento poetry its tone. Often, in the poems that aimed at popularity, produced, as it were, in the thick of it, the clashes between doggerel versification and ponderous imagery, between feeling and diction, are the major characteristics; the results, in the worst cases, can be a sort of unconscious caricature. Interestingly enough, in view of the problems of poetry for "the people", I seem to find no better example of this sort of self-parody than a poem by Aleardi the subject of which is the workers seduced by revolutionary ideas and going wild, turning into "plebe feroce" (*Il comunismo e Federico Bastiat*):

Lascian la sega, lasciano  
L'incudine sonora  
Que' furibondi, e sboccano  
Del lamentoso tetto.  
I rei sofismi cambiansi  
In palle di moschetto:  
Per le fumanti vie  
Gemono le agonie;  
E cento madri in lagrime  
De le stelle al pallor  
Cercheran fra i cadaveri  
Il figliuolo che muor.<sup>18</sup>

At the opposite end, I presume that a thorough enquiry into the poetry of the period would finally suggest that some of its most convincing results — of the happiest encounters between the popular and the relatively cultured, between speech communicable to "the people" and that dexterity of language without which there is no point in having professional writers at all — are to be found in specimens of the realistic-satiric vein. The major example here is Giusti; but even earlier makers of occasional

poems of that type, like Carbone and Dall'Ongaro, have their merits in the search for a "natural" idiom; one somehow feels that their popularity is healthier and more authentic than that of the official song-writers.

\* \* \*

It seems clear that the generations following the achievement of political unity hardly found themselves with a workable poetic image of the *patria*. Carrying matters to extremes of oversimplification we may say that the lacerated lady who was the object of the past poets' love and wrath, compassion and censure, somehow corresponded to a personal and historical experience in ways in which the official Italy of *l'elmo di Scipio*, of course, does not. I started by mentioning past poets as the country's natural interpreters and judges. Their task belongs to writers and artists in general. A major peculiarity of Italy is that this work of definition and expression, in terms of a modern nation and its concrete complexities, for more or less obvious historical, social, linguistic reasons has been protracted and still continues with an urgency perhaps unknown to other culturally relevant countries. Hence the contradictory quality of Italy's emblems, the peculiar way, we might say, that Italy has of being a nation. Frivolous as this may sound, it is perhaps not without interest that while the official, national-anthem image of Italy as more or less the Goddess Rome has naturally no relevance as a communal emblem of citizenship, the nation does not even possess any such items of household patriotic mythology as John Bull or Uncle Sam. The situation, in the present unhappy stage in the life of nationalisms, is not necessarily unfortunate or negative. The singularly composite, undefined, changeful quality of Italian culture may engender confusion and irritation on one side, but also, on the other, a healthy sense of openness and surprise,

expectancy, participation. And these undoubtedly are the basic reasons for the present resurgence of interest in the culture of Italy.

#### TRANSLATIONS

1. « Is this not the earth I touched first? . . . Is this not the fatherland in which I trust, / Benign and pious mother / That covers both my parents? »
2. . . . « Alas, how many wounds, / What pallor, what blood! oh such as I see you, / Most beautiful woman! »
3. « . . . her hair parted and without veil / She sits on the ground neglected and disconsolate, / Hiding her face / Between her knees, and cries. »
4. « Cry, for you have reason for it, my Italy, / Born to excel over all people / Both in happy and in adverse fate. »
5. « The sacrifice of the fatherland has been consummated. »
6. « The victim has been sacrificed ».
7. « it is like the Venice of his mind ending into the arms of Austria. »
8. I hoped that the genius of your early valor, which once made Rome the center of the world, was again born. Here, on the Alps, stand the centuries of your glory; they bear witness to your lords and to your people that you are not cowardly, not weak, but oppressed and betrayed, and that if you awaken to life, once again you will be queen. Upon you a fatal law of sorrow now finds its fulfillment, your hair is covered with ashes, your cloak is torn and ugly. But the hour of righteous wrath will sound, terrible, and may it teach fear to the barbarian oppressor.
9. The foreigner tramples upon my land, he slaughters my flocks, he attempts to deprive me of my honor; but I have one weapon left, a sword with which to pierce his heart. Are you not tired of the yoke, of the outrages, of the cowardly flattery, of the deceptions? Does this land bear only serfs and tyrants, and no longer any valiant men?
10. Farewell, my fair one, farewell, the army is leaving and if I also did not go it would be a cowardly deed.
11. « who always carries the fatherland in his heart. »
12. « She is alone before the people . . . Cursed is the woman who with her Italian embrace gave bliss to the Teuton soldier. »

13. « My poor Turi cannot come back! He is down at the bottom of the sea. »
14. « I am going to Lombardy / to face the oppressor. »
15. There is something in his eyes that shines forth from his mind and invites people to fall on their knees; still I saw him wander through the crowded squares, courteous and humane, extending his hand to young girls. Whether on a flowery path amidst song and music, or whether on the field amidst screaming bullets or cannon roars, he was born smiling nor could he appear different. Only to the enemy and to the cowards is his glance terrifying.
16. Go, Gismondo; and whatever I may be, do not mind my sorrow. You had a fatherland before you gave your heart to me; break her chains first, then rejoice in your love. Go; fight; and when you are in danger think, oh dear one, of the far-away day when seated among your children happily you will be able to say: « This devoted sword freed Italy from her serfdom. »
17. He bade farewell to Italy with serenity. A whirlwind of fog covered the rest. Toward noon, through the breaks in the fleeting clouds, the sun appeared hining on the deserted field, on the horrible rope, on the hanging corpse of a gentle man, now murdered, and on his neck, now livid, which once you would cover with kisses.
18. They cast aside the saw, the sonorous anvil, and furiously they emerge from the sorrowful abode. The ugly slogans become now bullets; on the smoking streets lie the wounded. Hundreds of mothers in tears seek out their dying sons in the pale light of the stars.

## Popular songs and hymns of the "Risorgimento"

CHARLES SPERONI

An important chapter in the history of the popular poetry of most peoples belongs to patriotic poetry and song: and as one might suppose, the more tormented and complex the history of an ethnic group or of a nation, the richer and more abundant its patriotic balladry. Because of the peculiar political history of the Italian nation, which in spite of its long cultural history, became an independent political entity almost a century after the United States, it is not surprising to find that the true flowering of her patriotic poetry and song coincides with the revolutions, battles, secret societies, and heroic deeds that brought about the amalgamation of Piedmontese, Lombards, Venetians, Tuscans, Sicilians, etc., into *Italians*, and the realization of national unity. It was during the Risorgimento, the "Resurgence", namely during those years that fall between the defeat of Napoleon in 1815 and the seizure of Rome by General Raffaello Cadorna in 1870, that the Italian "virtù" took up arms against the enemy's "furore", and even if the struggle was not as short as had been prophesied by Petrarch and Machiavelli, it became evident that the "antico valor" had not died in the Italian hearts.

It is interesting to bear in mind that the early part of the Risorgimento largely coincides with the Romantic movement, with that period, that is, when not only was there a keen interest in the mores, songs and traditions of the masses, of the "folk," but in the civic atmosphere created by the French revolution and the American De-